Ashoka's welfare statism it would be fair to say that it had, in a variant form and with different ends in mind, been enunciated before his time.[17]

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The fourteen major edicts, all formulated and inscribed in the third century BCE, seem to resemble an anthology now because we look at them as a group authored by the same king. But the fact that the edict set's locations are hugely diverse also makes aspects of them specific to each, while the thousands of kilometres separating them simultaneously suggest an asynchronous history that could be said to sometimes complement and at other times contradict the general impression of similitude.

Their composition was individual: each decree was composed and issued before being inscribed. The edicts themselves make this evident when alluding to the years in which Ashoka chose to issue specific decrees. As the last date that figures is the thirteenth year of coronation, the edicts could only have been set down after that event, though whether they were composed and erected immediately after or a couple of years later is not clear. Why the emperor now chose to get earlier promulgations inscribed in other parts of his empire—to which, at the time of engraving, many more texts were added—is also unclear. He was probably anxious to show them as part of an interconnected whole, much like different chapters of the same story. A symmetry of official accountability through the realm seems another strong part of the desiderata.

Since he began to dispatch the pronouncements individually they were not, obviously, a complete compilation at any single point in time. In several instances the edicts were dispatched in batches, with the pattern of dispatch showing many variations. We know this because of the pattern and placement of the writing, the Kalsi Rock Edict providing an instance. Kalsi is situated on the banks of the Yamuna river in Uttarakhand, at the junction of the plains and the hills, from where Hindu pilgrims are known to travel